

Assignment – 2

AI and Modern Warfare – Balancing Innovation with Ethical Integrity

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Abstract

Artificial Intelligence (AI) is quickly changing the face of contemporary warfare, bringing forth an unprecedented number of opportunities and ethical issues that cannot be overlooked. Autonomous weapons are expected to be efficient and less dangerous to human lives, but when machines decide to kill, many important questions arise regarding accountability (Watch, 2020). On the same note, national security is boosted by AI-powered surveillance and intelligence collection at the expense of civil liberties, privacy, and democratic principles ((OECD), 2019) (UNESCO, 2021). Additionally, the danger of unforeseen conflict expansion by means of algorithmic misperception or cyberwar implies the vulnerability of the world peace in the era of technological reliance (Cummings, 2021). This essay will critically evaluate these three aspects of the autonomous weapon, surveillance, and escalation using international conventions like the EU AI Act (Commission, 2021) and UN Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons (Affairs, 2021).

Introduction

Artificial Intelligence has become a defining change in the context of military innovation and is changing how countries are preparing and fighting a war. AI technologies will be fast, accurate, and minimize deaths in humans, autonomous drones, or predictive surveillance systems. However, these developments also come with some complicated ethical, social, and moral issues that must be addressed immediately.

Accountability is one of the greatest issues. Lethal decisions made by autonomous weapons create a blurred responsibility. The conventional principles of military ethics, including proportionality, distinction, and human constraints, are put to stress in case the machines are acting on their own (Singer, 2009). This is call to doubt the ability of the existing regulations of armed conflict to effectively combat moral dilemmas of AI-based warfare.

No less urgent are the implications of AI enabled surveillance and intelligence. Although these systems can help secure a nation, they could undermine privacy, civil liberties, and democratic freedoms ((OECD), 2019). The possible abuse of the surveillance technologies by the authoritarian governments explains the importance of the stringent ethical standards and global governance (UNESCO, 2021).

Conflict escalation is another important problem. The AI systems, especially those engaged in the cyberwarfare or autonomous defense can behave in an unpredictable manner, causing unwanted engagements. Minor geopolitical situations might be thrown out of balance by the errors or misunderstandings of algorithms, which would unnecessarily cause a mismatched reaction or trigger a war (Cummings, 2021).

The current set of ethical regulations, such as the UN Charter, Geneva Conventions, and more recent rules and guidelines devoted to AI, such as the EU AI Act (Commission, 2021) and OECD AI Principles ((OECD), 2019) are more or less helpful but can hardly keep up with the technological change. The ethical system of AI in war affairs should be transparent, accountable, and it should have a significant human control (UNESCO, 2021).

Thematic Review – Key Ethical Challenges

1. Autonomous Weapons and Accountability



One of the most debatable uses of AI in warfare is autonomous weapons. Such systems would include drones, robots in the form of tanks, and able to choose and attack targets without human intervention. Whereas the supporters believe that these weapons can save more human lives and save more efficiency, critics emphasize the deep ethical issues that they present.

The most important is the question of accountability. Who is responsible when making a lethal decision by a machine? Is it the one who created the algorithm, the one who implemented the system, or was it the one who approved its use, the policymaker? The assumption underlying international law and especially the Geneva Conventions is that there is human agency in a war. Autonomous weapons are a threat to this principle, and this aspect establishes a moral vacuum in which responsibility is decentralized (Affairs, 2021).

These concerns are depicted in real-life examples. In 2020, reports of independent drones working without human control made in Libya triggered the concerns of responsibility and control (Watch, 2020). Some organizations like the Human Rights Watch have recommended an upfront prohibition of killer robots on grounds that the delegation of life or death judgments to machines are degrading to the dignity of human beings and also that it goes against the principles of proportionality and distinction.

The UN Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons and the NIST AI Risk Management Framework provide the importance of human supervision and transparency ((NIST), 2023)). Nevertheless, implementation is still haphazard and military superiority tends to take precedence over morality in geopolitical rivalry.

2. AI in Surveillance and Intelligence



The use of AI-supported surveillance systems is becoming more popular in the military setting, which provides them with such features as facial recognition, predictive analytics, and real-time monitoring. These are technologies that contribute towards increased security of the nation since they detect threats and facilitate collection of intelligence. However, they have serious ethical issues.

The loss of privacy and civil liberties comes as the most urgent problem. Mass surveillance, especially used with facial recognition, can pose a threat of profiling, discrimination, and power misuse by tyrannical regimes ((OECD), 2019). The AI-based systems at military checkpoints can also focus on marginalized people disproportionately, contributing to social inequalities (UNESCO, 2021).

The OECD AI Principles and UNESCO guidelines, as well as other international organizations, emphasize privacy-by-design and transparency. The General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) of the EU offers robust protection to data transactions in a civilian setting, yet, in the military context, no protection is usually provided. This poses a threatening loophole where the surveillance technologies are installed with little responsibility (Commission, 2021).

The moral dilemma is in the trade-off between the national security and individual rights. Although the surveillance can be used to deter attack, excess may damage democratic principles and compromise citizenship. Surveillance done by AI should embrace ethics that are based on consent, transparency and proportionality so that safety is not compromised at the cost of liberty.

3. Conflict Escalation and Risk of Unintended Consequences



There is also a risk of accidental conflict escalation brought by AI technologies. Artificial defense, algorithms of cyberwarfare, and predictive models can behave in an unpredictable way, causing engagements that are not initiated by people.

Mistakes in an algorithm or its interpretation may be disastrous. To illustrate, when an AI device erroneously recognizes a civilian target as an adversary, it may result in a retaliatory attack, which will destabilize whole territories (Singer, 2009). Cyberwarfare weapon, which has been developed to shut down the infrastructure of the enemy, can cause damage to civilian infrastructure, which can widen the conflicts to unintended proportions (Cummings, 2021).

The moral duty of the countries and developers should be to be proportional and moderate. AI systems should have safeguards to avoid unforeseen escalation. Human control and transparency are also highlighted in the international discussions, e.g., in the work of the UN Group of Governmental Experts (Affairs, 2021).

Military AI is defined as high-risk in the EU AI Act, and it is bound to be closely monitored (Commission, 2021). Nevertheless, it is not easily enforced in a global environment where the competition of technologies spurs quick implementation. The threat of accidental AI-initiated wars is very high without the international regulation.

Discussion / Personal Reflection

The development of AI in contemporary warfare is one of the reasons that highlight the necessity of incorporating ethics into technological progress. The use of autonomous weapons, surveillance and escalation of conflicts also show that the unregulated use of AI has the potential to compromise human rights, civil liberties and even the stability of the world.

In my research, I got to know that the most burning issue is accountability. Lethal decisions may turn into a morally detached notion with no clear responsibility, which undermines the principles of international law and human dignity (Watch, 2020). The drone incident in Libya explains why accountability can disappear very fast when machines are left to do things on their own.

I also understood that surveillance technologies, although they increase security, are very dangerous to the privacy and democracy. Possible abuse of facial recognition in the military setting illustrates the necessity of a high level of ethical protection ((OECD), 2019) (UNESCO, 2021). Countries need to avoid the urge of putting short-term military benefit over long-term moral rectitude (Commission, 2021).

The risk that is likely to be the most unforeseen is the conflict escalation. Algorithms create errors that are affecting geopolitical situations, resulting in accidental wars that could be triggered by cyberwarfare misinterpretations (Cummings, 2021). This potential highlights the need to have transparency, proportionality, and human controls ((NIST), 2023).

Finally, to become responsible in AI use in warfare, the international regulation of AI, transparency, and meaningful control by humans is necessary. When implemented in a responsible manner, AI may save lives of human beings and enhance the quality of strategic decision-making. Nonetheless, when abused, it would undermine civil liberties and disrupt peace. Moral rather than technical, the use of ethical AI in war is a moral necessity. The decisions that are made today will either make AI a source of security and stability or a source of conflict and suppression (Singer, 2009).

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